

Mandarin, Step by Step, Character by Character

A composition-driven introduction to standard Mandarin

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Starter edition — seven short lessons in one cumulative chapter.

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How to use this starter edition

Begin with no assumed Chinese. Each section takes one small expression, teaches only the characters and sounds needed for it, shows what those characters are built from, and ends with a short retrieval prompt. There is no character list to memorise first.

Two things about Mandarin will be new to a reader coming from a European language, and this book meets both in its first chapter rather than deferring them. The first is that Chinese is written in *characters*, not letters: each one is an evenly sized block built from smaller recurring components, and words are one or more of those blocks. The second is that *pitch is part of the word*. Said on a high flat note, a falling note, or a low dipping one, the same syllable is three different words. That is not emphasis; it is as much a part of the word as a consonant.

This book is also honest about one thing it cannot do. A related language would let a new word be attached to English words the reader already owns through a shared ancestor — Spanish *gracias* to *grace* and *gratitude*. Chinese and English share no ancestor, so there are no cousins to show, and inventing some would be worse than having none. What replaces them here is the composition of the characters themselves: 好 is 女, woman, beside 子, child. That is a real and visible structure, and it does help — but it anchors a new word to knowledge you are acquiring in the same breath rather than to knowledge you already had, so it is a weaker hook than a shared ancestor would give. Where a component gloss is a traditional memory picture rather than settled history, this book says so.

Romanization (pinyin) stays beside the characters in this starter edition and will fade gradually. The variety taught is standard Mandarin in simplified characters; traditional characters are a labelled future edition, not a silent substitute.

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Chapter 1

Nǐ Hǎo — Hello, Character by Character

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in Mandarin and answer when greeted, reading both characters unaided and saying the greeting with the tone a speaker actually uses rather than the one the dictionary prints.

A two-line meeting in which both voices say the same word — read from the characters alone, with the first third tone raised by sandhi.

1.1 mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words

Nothing to recall yet. Before the first Chinese word arrives, one thing your voice is about to be asked to do that English never asks of it.

The sounds and tones in this word

In English, pitch carries mood. *Really.* and *Really?* are the same word, said two ways.

In Mandarin, **pitch is part of the word**, exactly the way a consonant is. Take the syllable *ma* and give it four different pitches and you get four unrelated words:

- **mā** — held high and flat, one steady note. *Mother.*
- **má** — rising, like the pitch on a surprised English “huh?”. *Hemp.*
- **mǎ** — dipping low, a little creaky. *Horse.*
- **mà** — falling sharply, like a clipped “No!”. *To scold.*

There is a fifth, the **neutral** tone: short, light, no mark written at all. The accent over the vowel is how the romanization writes the tone: a flat bar in **mā**, a rising stroke in **má**, a hook in **mǎ**, a falling stroke in **mà**. The Chinese characters themselves record no tone anywhere, so the accent is a teaching aid, not part of the writing. Say all four in order now, slowly: **mā, má, mǎ, mà**. [REPEAT x2]

Your turn

- *Say it:* **mā** high and flat, then **mà** falling — hear how far apart they are
- *Answer:* if you change the pitch of a Mandarin syllable, what changes?

Before you move on

Which accent tells you to dip low? (The hook, as in **mǎ**.) Does changing a Mandarin tone change how you feel about a word, or which word it is? (Which word it is.)

Source: the tone inventory this track keeps

1.2 你 — “you”, and the first character

Say the four tones on *ma* once, in order. Hold the third one — low and dipping. The first Chinese word carries exactly that pitch.

The sounds and tones in this word

nǐ. The *n* is the English *n*; the *i* is the *ee* of “see”. The hook over it is the **third tone**: start low, stay low, let it creak. [REPEAT x2]

Script — 你, and the person hiding on its left

Chinese is not written with letters. It is written with **characters**, each an evenly sized square block, and each block built from smaller recurring pieces called **components**.

你 has two of them, left and right:

亻 + 尔 → 你

亻 is the “person” component. On its own the character for a person is 人 — two legs walking. Push it to the left edge of a block and it is squashed upright into 亻 : one short slant over one vertical. Same piece, standing sideways to make room.

尔 on the right is there for its *sound*, not its meaning. Chinese builds most of its characters this way — one component pointing at the meaning, another at the pronunciation.

Stroke order is a real, taught system here: top before bottom, left before right. So 亻 first, then 尔.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

你 *nǐ* — **you**, addressing one person.

Here this book has to be honest with you. A related language lets a new word be anchored to English words you already own through a shared ancestor — Spanish *gracias* to *grace* and *gratitude*, all from Latin *gratia*.

Chinese shares no ancestor with English. There is no cousin web for *nǐ*, and inventing one would be worse than having none.

What replaces it is what you just read: the character is itself decomposable, and its pieces mean things. 你 carries a person on its left because it is about a person. That is the hook — not history you share with English, but structure you can see.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **nǐ** — low and dipping, not flat
- *Read it:* 你 — name its left piece, then its right piece

Before you move on

Which component of 你 tells you the word is about a person? (亻 .)

Source: Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart

1.3 好 — “good”, and what replaces etymology here

Say the word for “you” without looking. Which of its two components is the person? Now hold that low, dipping pitch — the

next word wants the same one.

The sounds and tones in this word

hǎo. The *h* is a little rougher than English *h*, scraped at the back of the mouth. The *ao* is one gliding vowel, the *ow* of “how”. The hook accent is the same third tone you already met: low, dipping, creaky. [REPEAT x2]

Script — 好, a woman beside a child

Two components again, side by side:

女 + 子 → 好

女 on the left is the character for “woman”: a crossing stroke, a curved leg, a horizontal through the middle. 子 on the right is “child”: a hooked top, a hooked vertical, a horizontal arm. Left before right, as always.

Notice what just happened. 女 and 子 are not letters spelling out the sound *hǎo* — neither is pronounced anything like it. They are whole characters with their own meanings, reused as building blocks.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

好 *hǎo* — **good**, and also **well**.

A woman beside a child, and the character means “good”. That picture is the hook — and it stands in for the cousin web that a related language would supply, because **Chinese and English share no ancestor** and there is no honest chain from *hǎo* to any English word.

Two cautions, because a memory aid that pretends to be history rots:

- “Woman + child = good” is the **traditional gloss**. It is genuinely useful for remembering the shape, but palaeographers do not all accept it as the historical origin; some read 子 as a phonetic element instead. A picture that helps, not a proven derivation.
- Component glosses are hooks, not translations. 好 does not “mean” woman-child. It means good.

Your turn

- *Say it: hǎo* — low and dipping, the *ow* of “how”

- *Read it:* 好 — name its left component, then its right one
- *Answer:* why does this track use component pictures instead of English cousins?

Before you move on

What does 好 mean? (Good, or well.) Is its woman-and-child picture a proven etymology? (No — a traditional and useful gloss, disputed as history.)

Source: Unicode Han database, character 好

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

Two characters, both already yours. Say the one that means “you”. Say the one that means “good”. Now put them in that order and you have said hello — but say it slowly for one more moment, because the tones are about to do something.

The exchange

你好 nǐ hǎo! Hello.

你好 nǐ hǎo! Hello.

The greeting and its answer are the same word. Say it to one person you have just met, at any hour of the day.

Grammar Lens — a word can be more than one character

English counts a word in **letters**. Chinese does not have letters, so the tempting guess is that it counts a word in **characters** — one character, one word. That guess is wrong, and correcting it early saves a great deal of confusion.

A character writes one **syllable** and usually one **meaningful piece**. A **word** is one or more of those pieces:

- 你 — one character, one word: *you*
- 好 — one character, one word: *good*

- 你好 — two characters, still **one word**: *hello*

Nobody hearing 你好 parses it as “you good”, any more than an English speaker hears “good” and “bye” inside *goodbye*. The pieces are visible, which makes the word easy to remember; the whole is what it means.

Why it’s said this way

你好 is safe, neutral, and understood everywhere — which is exactly why a course teaches it first. But it is worth knowing that it is used less freely than English “hello”. Between people who already know each other, a Mandarin speaker is more likely to open with a small situational remark than with 你好 at all. Reserve it for meeting someone, and you will sound right.

Your turn

- *Say it*: nǐ hǎo — greeting someone you have just met
- *Say it*: nǐ hǎo — answering that same greeting
- *Answer*: how many characters is this word, and how many words is it?

Before you move on

Which character comes first, and what does it mean on its own? (你, “you”.) Is 你好 one word or two? (One.)
Source: Unicode Han database, characters 你 and 好

1.5 ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written

Say the greeting once, slowly, giving both syllables the low dipping third tone you were taught. It should feel awkward in the mouth. That awkwardness is the whole lesson.

Grammar Lens — one rule, and it is not optional

When two third tones come one after the other, the first is spoken as a second (rising) tone.

So the greeting, written **nǐ hǎo**, is actually said **ní hǎo** — the first syllable climbs instead of dipping. [REPEAT x2]

Nothing about this shows in the writing. Dictionaries print **nǐ hǎo**, because that is the citation tone each word carries on its own, and the characters 你好 never change at all. A learner who trusts only what is written will say the commonest greeting in the language wrong every time.

Why does it happen? Two dipping tones in a row would need the voice to sink, climb, sink and climb again inside a fifth of a second. Speakers do not do that; the first one gives way. This is a real rule of the sound system, not a sloppy shortcut, and every native speaker applies it without thinking.

Compare it to what English does with “*the*”: written one way, said *thuh* before a consonant and *thee* before a vowel, and no English speaker thinks of that as two words. The difference is that here the change lands on **pitch** — the same property that distinguishes one word from another.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **ní hǎo** — first syllable rising, second dipping
- *Say it:* it again, at speaking speed, without the pause between them
- *Answer:* which spelling changes when the rule applies — pinyin, characters, or neither?

Before you move on

Two third tones meet. What happens to the first? (It rises.) What happens to the characters? (Nothing.)

Source: Chinese Text Project, on tone in Mandarin

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Name the character built from a woman and a child, and say what it means. Hold its tone: low and dipping.

The word, taken apart — what its characters are made of

The very same character, 好, has a second reading — and the only thing that separates the two is the tone:

- 好 *hǎo*, dipping third tone — **good**
- 好 *hào*, sharply falling fourth tone — **to be fond of, to like**

Same strokes. Same components. Same shape on the page. Two words. This is the cleanest proof available of what the first lesson claimed. Tone is not decoration on a word; it is *inside* the word, doing the job a consonant does in English. Change *hǎo* to *hào* and you have not said “good” with feeling — you have said a different word, the way *bat* and *pat* are different words.

The two readings are related in meaning, and the relation is a good hook: what is **good** is what one is **fond of**. That is a link inside Chinese, between two readings of one character. It is not a link to English. There is none.

You are not asked to produce **hào** yet. Recognising it is the point: when a familiar character turns up wearing an unfamiliar tone, the tone is telling you this is a different word.

Your turn

- *Answer:* **hǎo** or **hào** — which one means “good”?
- *Answer:* what changed between them, and what stayed the same?
- *Answer:* which two components is this character built from?

Before you move on

One character carried two words today. What told them apart? (Only the tone.)

Source: Unicode Han database, character 好

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Retrieve the two words separately first: the one meaning “you”, then the one meaning “good”. Do not run them together yet.

The exchange

A: 你好 *nǐ hǎo!* B: 你好 *nǐ hǎo!*

Two lines, one word, both voices. Every piece is already yours: the characters from their own lessons, the meaning from the greeting lesson, the rising first syllable from the sandhi rule. Nothing new is hiding here.

Say A’s line, pause, then answer as B. [REPEAT x2]

What you’ve built this chapter

Four things, and only one of them is vocabulary:

- 你 is 亻 plus 尔; 好 is 女 beside 子. Characters are built from parts.
- Those parts are the memory hook this track uses, because Chinese and English share no ancestor and therefore no cousin web.
- 你好 is two characters and one word. Characters are not letters.
- Pitch is part of the word, and a neighbouring word can change it without changing a stroke.

Your turn

- *Say it:* greet someone you have just met
- *Say it:* answer that greeting
- *Read it:* 你好 aloud from the characters alone, with no pinyin

Before you move on

Run both lines once more. If the first syllable dips instead of rising, go back to the sandhi lesson only — not to the whole chapter.

Source: Unicode Han database, characters 你 and 好

Pronunciation & Character Guide

Reference material, never a gate. Every lesson teaches the sounds its own word needs, inline, and links here for anyone who wants the fuller picture. Nobody has to read this page before Lesson 1, and most readers never will.

The ids in each heading are the values a lesson's **sounds**: frontmatter list points at.

Why this page is different from every other track's

In an alphabetic or abugida track, “the sounds you’ll need” is a list of *segments*: this letter is silent, that vowel is long, this consonant is retroflex. Each fact is attached to a letter, and the letter is on the page.

Mandarin adds a second, orthogonally different kind of fact. **Tone** rides on a whole syllable, is not written in the characters at all, and is *phonemic* — it distinguishes words the way a consonant does. A segmental note cannot express it. So this page has two halves: tones first, because they are the part an English speaker has no instinct for, then the segments.

The machine-readable form of the first half lives in the Chinese script reference under **tones** and **toneSandhi**.

Tones

Mandarin has four tones plus a neutral one. Pinyin writes the tone as a mark over the vowel; the characters do not record it anywhere.

The classic demonstration uses one syllable, *ma*:

- **tone-1** — first, high level (contour 55). Held high and flat, one steady note. *mā* — mother.
- **tone-2** — second, rising (35). Climbs from mid to high, like the pitch on a surprised English “huh?”. *má* — hemp.

- **tone-3** — third, dipping (214). Sinks low and creaky; said alone it rises again a little at the end, but in running speech it usually just stays low. *mǎ* — horse.
- **tone-4** — fourth, falling (51). Drops sharply from high to low, like a clipped “No!”. *mà* — to scold.
- **tone-neutral** — unstressed. Short and light, with no mark written at all, pitched by whatever came before it. *ma* — a question particle.

tone-lexical — tone is part of the word

The single fact that matters most, taught in the first lesson: changing the pitch of a Mandarin syllable changes **which word it is**, not how you feel about it. *mā*, *má*, *mǎ* and *mà* are four separate words. English uses pitch for mood and emphasis only, so this is a genuinely new job for an English speaker’s voice.

tone-sandhi-third — two third tones in a row

When a third tone is followed by another third tone, the first is spoken as a rising second tone.

Written **nǐ hǎo**, said **ní hǎo**. Neither the pinyin nor the characters record the change; dictionaries print the citation tone each word carries alone. This is why a reader who trusts only the page mispronounces the commonest greeting in the language.

tone-sandhi-bu — 不 before a fourth tone

不 *bù* is said *bú* when the next syllable has a fourth tone: *bù shì* → *bú shì*. Recorded here for completeness; no Chapter 1 lesson needs it.

Segments

Pinyin is a romanization, not English spelling. A few letters do work you would not guess.

- **pinyin-n** — as in English *no*.
- **pinyin-i** — after most consonants, the *ee* of “see”. (After *z-*, *c-*, *s-*, *zh-*, *ch-*, *sh-*, *r-* it is a different, buzzier vowel; no Chapter 1 word uses those.)

- pinyin-*h* — rougher than English *h*, scraped at the back of the mouth, closer to the *ch* of Scottish *loch* softened.
- pinyin-*ao* — one gliding vowel, the *ow* of “how”. Not two syllables.

The characters themselves

Stroke shapes, components, and stroke order for every character this track has introduced live in Chinese script reference. Unlike the Indic scripts in this curriculum, where stroke order is conventional, Chinese stroke order is a **taught, standardised system** — top before bottom, left before right, horizontal before vertical, outside before inside, and close a box last. That file marks its stroke orders **authoritative** for exactly that reason.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

好 *hǎo*

good, well

Introduced in Chapter 1.

你 *nǐ*

you (one person)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

你好 *nǐ hǎo*

hello (literally “you good”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 1

1.1 *mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words*

How many marked tones does Mandarin have, not counting the neutral one? Type the number as a word.

1.2 你 — “you”, and the first character

Type the Mandarin word, in pinyin with its tone mark, that means ‘you’ (one person).

1.3 好 — “good”, and what replaces etymology here

好 is built from two components. Type the meaning of the one on the left.

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

You have just been introduced to someone. Type the Mandarin greeting in characters.

1.5 *nǐ hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written*

A dictionary prints the greeting as nǐ hǎo. Type it in pinyin the way it is actually spoken.

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Read in the falling fourth tone, 好 stops meaning ‘good’. Type its meaning with that tone, in English.

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Someone greets you with 你好. Type your reply in characters.

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 1

1.1 *mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words*

Answer: four

Also accepted: 4

1.2 你 — “you”, and the first character

Answer: nǐ

Also accepted: ni3; ni

1.3 好 — “good”, and what replaces etymology here

Answer: woman

Also accepted: female; 女

1.4 你好 — the greeting, assembled from two things you already have

Answer: 你好

Also accepted: ni hao; nǐ hǎo; ní hǎo; nihao

1.5 ní hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written

Answer: ní hǎo

Also accepted: ni2 hao3; nihao (ní hǎo); ní hao

1.6 好 again — proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word

Answer: to be fond of

Also accepted: to like; like; fond of; be fond of

1.7 Practice — greet someone, and be greeted back

Answer: 你好

Also accepted: ni hao; nǐ hǎo; ní hǎo; nihao

Sources for this starter edition

Character shapes, components, and stroke order follow this project's curated character inventory, whose stroke orders are marked authoritative because Chinese stroke order is a standardised taught system rather than a convention. Codepoint and glyph references are to the Unicode CJK Unified Ideographs chart.

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

G

good, well 好 (hǎo)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

hello (literally “you good”) 你好 (nǐ hǎo)

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

M

mā má mǎ mà — one syllable, four words

pronunciation topic; explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 1, p. 1

N

Nǐ Hǎo — Hello, Character by Character

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

nǐ hǎo — why the greeting is not said the way it is written

pronunciation topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1

Y

you (one person) 你 (nǐ)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Other

好 again — **proof, on a character you own, that tone is the word**
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1